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12. Overindulgence: Enough Is Not Enough

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12. Overindulgence: Enough Is Not Enough

In my (Henry's) early years, one of my biggest problems was with drinking. Though I grew up in a Christian home where drinking was frowned upon, I rebelled in my teenage years and started drinking in bars, at parties, and in the homes of my friends.

Early signs of the danger in this lifestyle did little good. One of my drinking buddies burned to death in a fiery collision; another committed suicide. I was fired from a job for coming back from lunch drunk. But still I continued drinking.

Then one afternoon I staggered home drunk and dropped off to sleep on the couch. Soon a traveling salesman came to the door, shook me awake, and read me a tract about receiving Christ. I prayed with the salesman, asking God to forgive and save me, then fell back asleep.

I went to a bar as usual that evening, but somehow the lifestyle that had seemed so exciting before now seemed no fun at all. My drunken prayer had made a real difference! My life began to change and I left drinking behind completely, though not without some struggles.

As a result of my own experience, I am able to understand those who overindulge in alcohol or other substances and experiences. Both Bill and I have counseled hundreds of persons who have struggled with overindulgence of different sorts. We know the pain it can cause and the difficulty people have in beating these habits.

Of course, everyone overindulges occasionally. For example, just about every American overindulges with food on Thanksgiving. But what we are talking about here is an ongoing overindulgence that interferes with healthy and holy living.

Sinful overindulgence can take many forms. Let us first deal with what is perhaps the most common form: gluttony.

The Lure of the Refrigerator

A pastor had a heart attack and was clinging to life in the ICU of a local church-affiliated hospital. The pastor's adult son came to visit him in the hospital and was praying by his side when a doctor came in. They discussed the father's condition, and the doctor informed the son that being overweight had put a strain on his father's heart.

Then the doctor pointed out that the son seemed to be heading down the same road. And it was true. Like his father, the son had a sedentary lifestyle and enjoyed large quantities of convenience foods. His belly was already well on its way to matching his father's girth.

"Yeah, I've got an eating problem," admitted the son.

"No, you've got a sin problem," countered the doctor.¹

Overeating is the more common term these days, but *gluttony* is the time-honored label for the sin of putting more food in your mouth than your body needs for its health and strength. A glutton is the type of person who tells himself or herself, “Eat, drink, and be merry!” (Luke 12:19). In the worst cases, you could say of gluttons that “their god is their stomach” (Philippians 3:19 niv).

For some gluttons, the appeal of overeating lies in the enjoyment that the taste buds get as the food makes its way to the stomach. For others, the sense of fullness that comes after eating may compensate for emotional absences in their lives. Yet while one might understand and sympathize with some causes for overindulgence with food, we must say unequivocally that gluttony is a sin.

Like any sin, gluttony trails in its wake a host of evil effects. Those who overeat often feel ashamed and guilty. They spend more of their money and time on food than it deserves. As they gain weight, they experience discomfort, reduced physical abilities, and embarrassment over how others view them. And like the pastor who had the heart attack, they may experience significant health problems. Each year, obesity in America accounts for health-care costs of approximately \$100 billion as well as contributes to at least three hundred thousand premature deaths.²

Gluttony can also damage one’s spiritual health. Philosopher Cornelius Plantinga Jr. pointed out, “Full stomachs and jaded palates take the edge from our hunger and thirst for righteousness. They spoil the appetite for God.”³ The person whose body is overfed may have a starving soul.

The same sort of spiritual deprivation may be at work in those with a drinking problem.

Bliss in a Bottle?

For years, Jack Bivans was one of the voices on the popular radio theater program *Unshackled!* Produced by the Pacific Garden Mission in Chicago, *Unshackled!* portrayed the ways that real individuals were freed from alcoholism and other bondages through the power of Christ. What few listeners knew was that Bivans was in shackles himself.

Bivans began drinking while serving in World War II. Over the years, his drinking got worse and contributed to the dissolution of two marriages. “My family life began a downward spiral and my emotional world started crumbling around me,” he recalled.

It all came to a head in 1975. Bivans said, “The lives of the people whose true stories I had portrayed on *Unshackled!* began to hit home. One day, following a taping, I was driving home alone and felt the overwhelming presence of the Holy Spirit within me. I changed. I was drinking, and sometimes too much, and so I gave it up.”⁴

Of all forms of overindulgence, none is more thoroughly covered in Scripture than drunkenness. Perhaps most notably, Solomon composed a vivid description of the effects of drinking upon the drunkard:

*Who has anguish? Who has sorrow? Who is always fighting? Who is always complaining? Who has unnecessary bruises? Who has bloodshot eyes? It is the one who spends long hours in the taverns, trying out new drinks. Don't gaze at the wine, seeing how red it is, how it sparkles in the cup, how smoothly it goes down. For in the end it bites like a poisonous snake; it stings like a viper. You will see hallucinations, and you will say crazy things. You will stagger like a sailor tossed at sea, clinging to a swaying mast. And you will say, "They hit me, but I didn't feel it. I didn't even know it when they beat me up. When will I wake up so I can look for another drink?" —Proverbs 23:29-35*⁵

The Romans liked to indulge in drinking parties where matters could get way out of hand. The apostle Peter, therefore, wrote to new believers, “You have had enough in the past of the evil things that godless people enjoy—their immorality and lust, *their feasting and drunkenness and wild parties*, and their terrible worship of idols” (1 Peter 4:3, emphasis added).⁶ The message for Christians who have been heavy drinkers is this: Enough! It is time to put away your habit of drunkenness.

Paul made God’s viewpoint on drunkenness as clear as it could be: “Don’t be drunk with wine, because that will ruin your life.” Then Paul went on to say, “Instead, be filled with the Holy Spirit” (Ephesians 5:18). Rather than being under the influence of alcohol, we should be under the influence of God’s Spirit.

Drugs: When Escape Becomes a Trap

Unlike alcohol, drugs are not specifically mentioned in Scripture. However, the New Testament word usually translated “witchcraft” or “sorcery” (“participation in demonic activities” in Galatians 5:20) is *pharmakeia*, from which we get our word *pharmaceuticals*. It reflects the fact that mood-altering substances were often used in occult rituals in ancient times.

It is a safe bet that we can take the biblical injunctions against drunkenness as applying to drug abuse as well. We can therefore paraphrase Ephesians 5:18 as saying, “Don’t take drugs, because that will ruin your life.” The very fact that drug use is illegal puts it out of bounds for Christians, since we are instructed to “submit to governing authorities” (Romans 13:1).

Drug-taking is one sin that many presume Christians will not get involved in. Not so! Singer Johnny Cash is an example. Not long before his death in 2003, Cash told *Relevant* magazine,

*I used drugs to escape, and they worked pretty well when I was younger. But they devastated me physically and emotionally—and spiritually. That last one hurt so much: to put myself in such a low state that I couldn’t communicate with God. There’s no lonelier place to be. I was separated from God, and I wasn’t even trying to call on him. I knew that there was no line of communication. But he came back. And I came back.*⁷

As in Cash’s case, escape seems to be one motivation of people who take drugs. They think they can leave the difficulty or tedium of their lives behind with the vehicle of drugs. Unfortunately, it does not get them anywhere; they wind up in worse trouble than they started with.

Meanwhile, many drugs have a powerfully addicting effect on those who take them. Drug users still have a choice (that’s where the sinfulness comes in), but as the addiction changes their brain chemistry and physiological responses, the choice *not* to take drugs becomes harder and harder. Many find that their temporary “escape” becomes a trap they cannot seem to work their way out of.

Actor Robert Downey Jr. said, “I’m allergic to alcohol and narcotics. If I use them, I break out in handcuffs.” We can laugh at the quip, but the fact is that drug users, while they may not be literally imprisoned as Downey has been, are bound emotionally and spiritually.

Shopping as Recreation

Some have said that America has been infected with “affluenza.” Materialism is a widespread illness, and for many it shows up in the way they buy far more than they really need. They shop just for the fun of it, and for the kick they get from owning

new stuff, not because they really need these belongings. A term has been coined to describe these people: *shopaholics*.

While the term is new, the phenomenon it describes is not. Long ago, King Solomon went through a phase in which he deliberately tested what he could gain by spending, spending, spending.

I...tried to find meaning by building huge homes for myself and by planting beautiful vineyards. I made gardens and parks, filling them with all kinds of fruit trees. I built reservoirs to collect the water to irrigate my many flourishing groves. I bought slaves, both men and women, and others were born into my household. I also owned large herds and flocks, more than any of the kings who had lived in Jerusalem before me. I collected great sums of silver and gold, the treasure of many kings and provinces. I hired wonderful singers, both men and women, and had many beautiful concubines. I had everything a man could desire! —Ecclesiastes 2:4-8

What was Solomon's conclusion after his spending spree? "This is all so meaningless!" (verse 15)

We do not mean to imply that all buying is bad. God loves to bless His children. It is a good thing when we can meet our own needs and even indulge our moderate and reasonable desires for pleasure. The problem lies in excessive accumulation of "stuff" out of a desire to meet some inner need.

We will let you decide, through seeking the mind of Christ in prayer, what "excessive" means for you. But one thing we know: possessions do not confer meaning upon a person's life. Jesus said plainly, "Beware! Guard against every kind of greed. Life is not measured by how much you own" (Luke 12:15).

Neither do possessions provide real security, though some people may think they do. In His Sermon on the Mount, Jesus taught about this also:

Don't store up treasures here on earth, where moths eat them and rust destroys them, and where thieves break in and steal. Store your treasures in heaven, where moths and rust cannot destroy, and thieves do not break in and steal. Wherever your treasure is, there the desires of your heart will also be. — Matthew 6:19-21

As if to illustrate His words in the Sermon on the Mount, at another time Jesus told a story about a farmer who had a string of good harvests. He began to base a hedonistic plan on his wealth. “I’ll sit back and say to myself, My friend, you have enough stored away for years to come. Now take it easy! Eat, drink, and be merry!” (Luke 12:19).

But Jesus said this man was a fool, because that very day was marked down in God’s calendar as the day when he would be called to account for his life. The lesson Jesus drew from this story is simple: “A person is a fool to store up earthly wealth but not have a rich relationship with God.” (See Luke 12:16-21.)

Media Mad

Our media options are proliferating like never before. Not only do we have television, radio, and movies, but now we also have computerized gaming systems, the Internet, DVDs, MP3s, handheld computers, and more. Some people spend untold hours with these media, living vicariously through televised sports or reality TV shows or video games, and there are a couple of problems with this.

First, excessive use of media can have a mind-numbing effect. A person who spends hours every week playing Xbox games has some fun and develops a certain type of skill, but is he really becoming a wiser, deeper, more godly person? It is not likely.

Second, too much time with entertainment distracts from other activities that are equally or more important. For example, someone who has what is dubbed a “Net addiction” may spend so much time online that she neglects her schoolwork, job, or family.

Perhaps we are in something like the position of the wealthy people of Judah in the prophet Amos’s time. Amos warned,

*How terrible for you who sprawl on ivory beds and lounge on your couches, eating the meat of tender lambs from the flock and of choice calves fattened in the stall. You sing trivial songs to the sound of the harp and fancy yourselves to be great musicians like David. You drink wine by the bowlful and perfume yourselves with fragrant lotions. You care nothing about the ruin of your nation. Therefore, you will be the first to be led away as captives. —Amos 6:4-7
emphasis added*

Clearly the upper classes of Judah were overindulging in a number of types of luxury, including some we have already covered. As part of their error, they were indulging excessively in the entertainment of music when they should have been attending to more important matters.

Will the consequences for us be “terrible” (as Amos said) if we keep spending our lives with our eyes glued to video screens and with earphones stuffed in our ears? It would be better not to find out.

Appetites out of Control

Along with more obvious forms of overindulgence, there are many other ways people may let their appetites get out of control like a stallion that leaps a fence. A mother might spend far more time working out at the gym than she needs to keep in shape, neglecting her family responsibilities in the process. A young might love the adrenaline rush from thrill-seeking activities, such as extreme skiing and class-5 river rafting, to the point that he risks his life. And what about caffeine? Or cigarettes?

As diverse as are the moral weak points of the human race, so diverse are the forms overindulgence may take. Yet all forms of overindulgence have something in common: they are ways of feeding an appetite. “All sins are attempts to fill voids,” claimed Simone Weil. That is certainly true of the sins of overindulgence.

People have a type of hunger, real or perceived, and then try to feed it in a way that is inappropriate. Maybe they are greedy for sensation. Or maybe they have an emotional hurt and are trying to mask it with a high or the yumminess of a dessert or a “fun fix.” Either way, they need to understand their real problem and address it in a healthy way. Overindulgence will only make matters worse.

Other motivators may also contribute to an overindulgence problem. For example, someone may abuse drugs as a way of rebelling against his strict upbringing. Rebellion, anger, disobedience—these are just a few of the sins that may complicate our tendencies toward self-indulgence.

“But wait,” you might say. “Is overindulgence really our fault? Might the real issue be illness, not sin?” Let’s consider that.

The Medical Model

One day I (Bill) received a call from the wife of an alcoholic. The woman said her husband was a wonderful person when he was sober but a demon when he was drinking. Why did he keep drinking?

Another day I talked with a young man who was on drugs. He was deathly afraid that he would be caught, end up in jail, and get a police record. Still, something about drugs wooed him to go on another trip, to smoke another joint.

These people have a compulsion to continue in their particular form of overindulgence—no doubt about it. Many others have the same problem. But how are we to understand such a compulsion?

The preferred approach at present is to use a medical model. In other words, people who cannot seem to stop drinking or taking drugs are deemed to have a disease, called an addiction. A genetic cause is at the root of the addiction, and the addiction needs to be treated with methods commonly used for other physical and emotional diseases.

There is some value in the medical model. Along with such factors as personality or temperament, a person's genes may give him or her some predisposition to addictive behavior. And sometimes medical treatments, such as methadone treatments for heroin addicts, have proved helpful. But even given such advantages, the medical model is woefully incomplete.

By labeling overindulgent behaviors a "disease," the medical model effectively cuts off the spiritual and ethical aspects of the human being involved. A person's behavior may be an addiction, but it is also *sin*. We have a responsibility—and a real potential—to do what is right, even if we have allowed a certain substance to gain a measure of control over us. Ultimately overindulgence is treatable only by the soul surgery of repentance.

That's what a young man named Franklin found out to his great surprise.

A Liar Who Encountered the Truth

Franklin had it all—all the problems you could imagine, that is. He liked to drink too much, take illegal drugs, and sleep around with both men and women. He was also insecure, unhappy, and riddled with guilt. He knew his life was a time bomb waiting

to go off, but he had no idea of how to talk to God about his problems. Finally he went to a counselor.

“Doc, I need to quit drinking and doing drugs. But I can’t stop.” Franklin started to sob.

“Well,” the counselor replied, “I’m glad you are here. But I already have my doubts that you are ready to change. You’ve said two things to me, and one of them is not true. We are not going to get anywhere with an attitude like that.”

“Lying? What are you talking about? I need help, not word games!”

“You said something irrational, Franklin. You said you couldn’t stop drinking and using drugs. Are you drinking and using drugs right now, or are you talking to me?”

Franklin said, “Of course I’m not taking drugs now! I’m talking to a worthless counselor who accuses me of lying the moment I sit down!”

“Then,” the counselor replied, “you admit that you can control when you abuse yourself and when you do not?”

Franklin began to think about his level of control. He did not drink until after 5:30 p.m. He did not do illegal drugs except on certain days. He had a favorite drink (gin and tonic) and would not touch domestic beer. He actually began to relax as he described his favorite blend of drugs and alcohol and how, if he timed it right, he could party all night, get an hour’s sleep on the bus going to work, and take an “upper” with his first cup of coffee and work all day without a break.

This took up most of Franklin’s first session. Before he left, the counselor asked two questions: “Franklin, why do you enjoy talking about the greatest enemies you have—the very things that will kill you if you don’t stop using them to alter your thoughts, feelings, and behaviors? Why are you so angry at God that you would keep lashing out at Him in flagrant disobedience?”

Franklin did not have an answer to those questions. But he had started thinking in a new way.

Choose Your Master

Would Franklin submit to the control of God, or would he give up control to his appetites? All people who overindulge face the same question.

Not being controlled is not an option. We were made to worship and to serve another outside ourselves. And so we will always serve someone or something, and many choose to make their appetite their god, whether that appetite is for Jim Beam whiskey or lines of white powder or a third plateful at Country Buffet. The only worthy master is God. He is the one we were made to serve.

Of course, there is such a thing as Christian freedom. Some would justify indulging their appetites on the basis of that freedom.

But the apostle Paul preempted such an argument: “You say, ‘I am allowed to do anything’—but not everything is good for you. And even though ‘I am allowed to do anything,’ I must not become a slave to anything” (1 Corinthians 6:12).

No, we must not become a slave to anything. Not drink. Not drugs. Not food. Not anything. We must serve God alone. As we do so, He will enable us to make better choices in what we will consume. He will heal us spiritually, enabling us to partake of substances or experiences in moderation (if limited consumption is safe) or keep a distance from whatever substance or experience threatens to destroy us.

Everything in Moderation

Have you had enough of too much? Are you willing to admit that your overindulgence is a sin? If so, we hope you will take action now by emptying your life of the sin and by filling the empty space with something far better. The virtue with which we should replace a sin of overindulgence is *moderation*.

“Do you like honey?” asked Solomon. “Don’t eat too much, or it will make you sick!” (Proverbs 25:16). This call to moderation is appropriate to many but not all kinds of overindulgence.

Moderation is the proper response when overindulgence often involves substances or experiences that are good in themselves. In itself, food is good; we need it to survive and it provides enjoyment. In themselves, a house and the things we put in it are good; they help us to live our lives in safety and satisfaction. In itself, entertainment is good; it gives us both relaxation and mental stimulation. What’s bad is when we use these good things to the point of excess. Defining what is “excess” is a challenging, personal struggle.

This perversion of the good for evil is a pattern that has long been understood. Eighteenth-century devotional writer William Law said,

Our souls may receive an infinite hurt, and be rendered incapable of all virtue, merely by the use of innocent and lawful things....

What is more lawful than eating and drinking? And yet what more destructive of all virtue, what more fruitful of all vice, than sensuality and indulgence?...

Now it is for want of religious exactness in the use of these innocent and lawful things, that religion cannot get possession of our hearts. And it is in the right and prudent management of ourselves, as to these things, that all the art of holy living chiefly consists.⁸

In other cases, however, overindulgence involves substances or experiences that are wrong, period. Shooting heroin, for example, is always illegal and always destructive. The response in a situation like this should be what we might call an extreme form of moderation: abstinence. Here, any indulgence is overindulgence.

Also, there are the gray areas. We can all agree that it is wrong to get drunk, since the Bible is so clear on that point, but should Christians drink only in moderation or should they not drink at all? Both the authors of this book have chosen not to drink at all, so as to avoid any risk associated with drunkenness or dependence on alcohol. We would advise anyone else who has had a problem with overindulgence to likewise avoid the risk of drunkenness by avoiding alcohol altogether. For the rest, we say again: moderation. Through prayer, you can seek God's help to know whether moderation or abstinence is right for you in a given instance—and what “moderation” would mean in your case.

Truly, moderation is what God wants to see in our lives. As we overindulge in our favorite ways, God grieves because He knows we are not filling ourselves with what we really need, and that is more of Himself. We can never get too much of God.

Soul Prescription for Overindulgence

Are you struggling with some form of overindulgence? We have outlined a five-step process to help you repent and heal in this area of your life. Take all the time you need with each of the steps below.

Step 1: Adopt a Correct View of God

If you are overindulgent with yourself, it is important that you understand God better as the loving Father. He has promised you that He will always provide for your physical, emotional, and spiritual needs. You do not need to stuff yourself with whatever you can get your hands on.

- God is all-knowing. He designed you and knows what would make you the happiest.
I know the plans I have for you,” says the LORD. “They are plans for good and not for disaster, to give you a future and a hope. —Jeremiah 29:11
- God is love. He will always give you only what is good for you.
Whatever is good and perfect comes down to us from God our Father, who created all the lights in the heavens. —James 1:17
- God is faithful. He will always provide for your needs.
The LORD will withhold no good thing from those who do what is right. —Psalm 84:11

Do not let a warped view of God justify your overindulgent lifestyle any longer. Undertake a search of Scripture for passages that depict God as your provider who satisfies you.

Step 2: Revise Your False Beliefs

God has called you to a life of holiness and moderate living. When you choose a different course for life, it proves that you really do not believe God will hold you accountable for your actions.

- Do you believe you have the right to party excessively?
You have had enough in the past of the evil things that godless people enjoy—their immorality and lust, their feasting and drunkenness and wild parties, and their terrible worship of idols. —1 Peter 4:3
- Do you believe you have no choice in controlling your appetites?
Therefore, dear brothers and sisters, you have no obligation to do what your sinful nature urges you to do.—Romans 8:12
- Do you believe you are not responsible for your sinful overindulgence?
We are each responsible for our own conduct. —Galatians 6:5

Try as you may, you just cannot lay the responsibility for your excessive self-indulgence on the shoulders of anyone other than yourself. Learn from Scripture what is really true about self-indulgent behavior versus self-control.

Step 3: Repent of Your Sin

You must make the decision to turn away from your lifestyle of overindulgence and to disconnect your heart, mind, and spirit from that which enslaves you. Give your particular type of overindulgence a name (drunkenness, gluttony, or whatever else it may be).

Confess your sin to God and ask His forgiveness. If you wish, you can use the following prayer (inserting your own sin in the blank).

Father, I have sinned against you by _____. I know that this hurts You, and I am sorry for that. Please forgive me for the sake of Christ. Make me clean, Lord, removing from my heart the desires that have enslaved me. Fill me with the Holy Spirit, and through Him give me the strength to walk the path of righteousness one day at a time. In Jesus' name, amen.

If you have harmed others with your sin, apologize to them. Seek reconciliation and offer restitution where appropriate.

Step 4: Defend against Spiritual Attacks

Now that you have repented and been set free from your sin, this freedom must be defended. You have to understand the tactics of your enemies and defend against them accordingly.

- The world tells you, “It’s your body and you can do what you want with it.” Overcome the world system by rejecting such a distorted value. Embrace the value God places on self-control and moderation over self-indulgence. Listen to Him and not to the world.
- Your flesh wants the gratifications of physical sensations. So when such desires arise, remember that your flesh is dead; you are now living by the Spirit. You do not have to do what your flesh wants.
Those who live only to satisfy their own sinful nature will harvest decay and death from that sinful nature. But those who live to please the Spirit will harvest everlasting life from the Spirit. —Galatians 6:8

- Satan will encourage you to satisfy your desires for excessive self-indulgence. Hold up the “shield of faith” to stop the fiery arrows of the devil (Ephesians 6:16), showing you realize that ungodly self-indulgence does not offer lasting satisfaction.

The temptation to overindulge oneself tends to be especially persistent in a person’s life. Plan on remaining vigilant toward your enemies’ attacks for the rest of your life. The battle is long, but in God’s power you *can* be victorious.

Step 5: Flee Temptation

Take proactive measures if you wish to remain free from the sin of overindulgence. By reducing temptation, you can improve the chances of your success.

- Focus on your relationship with God.
Start every day with God. Give Him your attention and devotion instead of concentrating on the thing that once held you captive to your selfish desires. Consider fasting periodically as a reminder that “People do not live by bread alone, but by every word that comes from the mouth of God.” —Mathew 4:4
- Latch on to God’s promises.
Find truths in Scripture that will encourage you in your resistance to the temptations of overindulgence. Memorize key verses for recall when you need them. Here is one verse we recommend:
The Holy Spirit produces this kind of fruit in our lives: love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and *self-control*. There is no law against these things! —Galatians 5:22-23, emphasis added
- Establish safeguards.
What situations tend to encourage your excessive self-indulgence? Take decisive action to avoid those situations as much as possible. For example:
 - If you are irresponsible in your eating, plan reasonable menus a week at a time and buy only what you will need.
 - If you get drunk, remove all the alcohol from your house, ask your friends not to serve alcohol when you are around, and never go to an eating establishment that serves liquor.
 - If you watch too much TV, get rid of your television set or put a timer on it.
 - Ask a trusted Christian friend to hold you accountable in your commitment to not overindulge.

- Expect victory.

You have the Spirit of God living in you and imparting to you everything you need to win this fight. Yield to Him daily in anticipation of total deliverance from your sin habit. When you do this, He will replace your self-indulgent desires with moderation and self-control.

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